

the mind of my customers. One complaint meant there were 10 others who felt the same way. When my black book accumulated similar complaints weekly, I had to evaluate the issue and take corrective action. *Complaints are the world's whispers hinting the direction you should be moving.*

THE FOUR TYPES OF ROAD NOISE (COMPLAINTS)

When the world unleashes its opinion on your new Web site, product, or concept, what should you expect? What should be addressed and what should be ignored? There are four types of complaints: 1) Complaints of change 2) Complaints of expectation 3) Complaints of void and 4) Complaints of fraud.

Complaints of Change

Take anything that people love, change it, and you'll have a riot at the steps of your business. Remember when Coke changed its formula? Oh heavens! How dare they! Remember when Fox canceled the feel-good family drama *Party of Five*? Dear God! The world hates change, and it's a natural human behavior to resist change. Change endangers comfort, expectancy, and security.

When I redesigned my Web site and hundreds of complaints poured in, I expected a certain degree of resistance. It's normal. In fact, every redesign I've ever done in 10-plus years was met with resistance. The question for critique was, how much was normal? And how much was legitimate?

Complaints of change are the least informative and therefore are the ones most difficult to decipher. For my redesign failure, data confirmed that the complaints were substantial. Bounce rates tripled and my conversion ratio suffered. I had to suck up the failure, revert back, and start over. When you change, there will be complaints. Guaranteed. And yes, not all of them are actionable simply because human psychology is in play, not the integrity of your work.

Complaints of Expectation

Complaints of expectation occur when you negatively violate the expectation of your customer. You convince them to do business with you, they expect something, and what you provide doesn't meet that expectation. This happens because either your service failed or their expectation was malformed by a deceptive marketing strategy. Regardless of which, both expose a problem. And it's your problem, not the customer's. You either need to do a better job in fulfillment or a better job in managing their expectations.

"Your service sucks." I heard that complaint hundreds of times and yet my company not only survived, it thrived. If my service sucked and I was being told it sucked, how did my business succeed? I dug into the claims.

Advertisers who complained, "Your service sucks," didn't use my service as intended. Their expectations were malformed. I owned a lead generation service